

You assign a skin to a single component instance at compile time by setting `skinClass` with an inline style declaration. When assigning a skin to the `Application` component, this strategy makes the most sense, since by definition there is only one instance of that component. The value of the `skinClass` style should be set to the fully qualified package and name of the custom skin component. To use the custom skin that was created in the previous section, set the `<s:Application>` tag's `skinClass` attribute to `skins.CustomAppSkin`.

You can also apply custom skins with style sheet declarations. While this strategy is most useful when applying a skin to a group of components (such as all objects that are instances of a particular Spark component), it can be used with any Spark component, including `Application`. As with all styles, the declaration starts with a CSS selector that defines which components will have the style applied. You can use type selectors, style name selectors (also known as class selectors), contextual selectors, or any other syntax that's supported in the Flex 4.5 SDK. The value of the `skinClass` style is set using the `ClassReference()` compiler directive. You pass the fully qualified package and name of the custom skin component. The following code assigns a skin named `MyCustomButtonSkin` to all instances of the `Spark Button` component:

- `s|Button: ClassReference("skins.MyCustomButtonSkin");`

You can also load a custom skin at runtime using the `setStyle()` method or any of the techniques available with the `StyleManager` class. For example, the following code adds the custom skin to the application:

- `this.setStyle("skinClass", skins.CustomAppSkinComplete);`

You can also get a reference to the class being currently used as a skin using the `getStyle()` method:

- `var currentSkin:Class = this.getStyle("skinClass") as Class;`

Skinning other Spark components

You can create custom skins for all Spark components, including your own custom components. In this section we describe the specific code you need to skin the `Spark Button` and `List` components. In Flash Builder, you can get started with custom skinning by creating a copy of a component's default skin class. This tool is available only from Flash Builder's design mode.

1. Open `AppWithButtons.mxml` in Flash Builder. Notice that the application uses a completed version of the custom application skin created in a